

Emotions

Emotions are physiological responses to external events, shaped by experience, that are accompanied by distinctive feelings. They evolved to push us away from danger and toward reward.

Basic emotions

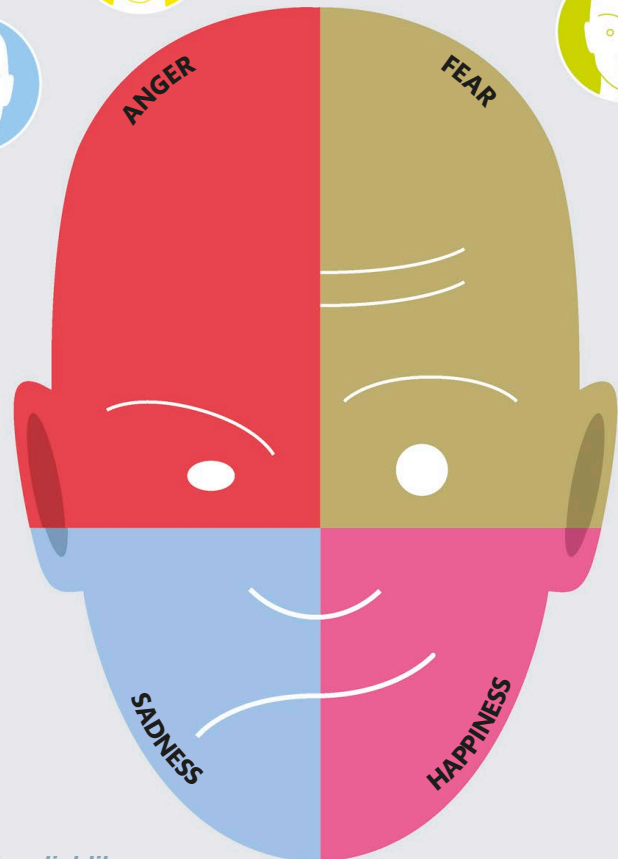
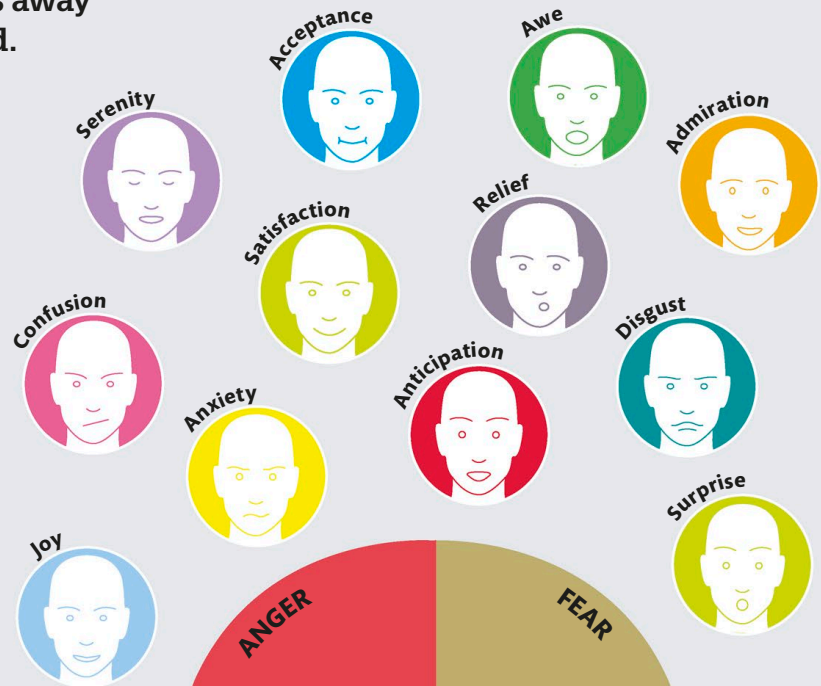
Research suggests that there are four physiologically distinct conscious feelings: anger, fear, happiness, and sadness. Aspects of these combine and allow us to feel a range of emotions. Broadly, emotions are positive or negative experiences, which vary in intensity. Different emotional states are associated with particular physiological changes that affect how a person behaves and thinks. For example, we view the world differently when we are relaxed and when we are afraid. This coordination of physiology, behavior, and thought with feeling is what makes us adapt our behavior in response to events.

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Other emotional experiences stem from the four key ones. A recent study found there may be 27 types of emotional experiences, some of which are shown here. Certain emotions lie along gradients, such as moving from anxiety to fear to horror.



HORMONES THAT TRIGGER EMOTIONAL RESPONSES ARE ABSORBED IN 6 SECONDS



WHY DO WE CRY?

Only humans cry, and nobody is certain why we do it—especially given that both sadness and joy can evoke tears. Crying serves an interpersonal function, signaling that we are in emotional distress to evoke appropriate social responses. It is also cathartic, enabling full emotional engagement and processing that is good for mental health.

